

Cheese Around the World

While milk might taste the same throughout the world, cheese is the consummate individual. Climate, history, tradition, landscape, the eating habits and the breed of the animal, and the dexterity of the cheesemaker all help ensure that the slice is right, from the lofty French Alps to the flatlands of Holland and the heart-shaped island of Tasmania.

THE FRENCH ALPS

Coopérative Laitière de Haut Tarentaise

www.fromagebeaufort.com

The Dairy Cooperative of the High Tarentaise has shops in Bourg St-Maurice, Val d'Isère, Les Arcs, La Rosière, and Tignes selling Beaufort cheese, dubbed "the prince of Gruyères." A hard, cooked cheese, it is pressed into beechwood molds to shape it, then drained, turned, and rubbed with salt daily, and aged for six months.

La Laiterie des Halles

2 place de Genève, Chambéry; www.fromager-denis-provent.com

Denis Provent, who runs La Laiterie des Halles, is a master of Savoie cheeses; his family has been in the *fromage* business for three generations. His shop in Chambéry brims with Savoie cheeses, including Reblochon Fermier, Abondance, Beaufort, Tome de Bauges (semi-soft cow cheese), Tomette de Brebis de Savoie (sheep cheese), and Tarentais (farmhouse goat cheese). Provent ages many of the cheeses in his own cellars. He has a second cheese "boutique," Les Délices Savoyardes, on rue de Genève in Aix-les-Bains.

Le Grand-Bornand

www.legrandbornand.com

Farms in and around this pretty winter-sports village near Annecy welcome visitors during the summer months to see Reblochon Fermier (farmhouse Reblochon) cheese being made, from the milking of the cows to a tasting of the final creamy product. Le Grand-Bornand, with some 55 farms in operation, boasts as many cows (2,000) as people! Le Grand-Bornand Tourist Office organizes tours.

NORMANDY, FRANCE

The land of cows, apple trees, and thatched roofs produces one of France's most famous cheeses – the fruity Camembert – as well as Pont l'Évêque, Livarot, and Brillat-Savarin.

La Foire aux Fromages de Livarot

A festival featuring all the finest local cheeses is held in Livarot, in the heart of Camembert country, every August. Brave souls can attempt to win the title of fastest Livarot cheese-eater; the current record is 26 oz (750 g) in 1 minute 51 seconds.

La Fromagerie François Olivier

40 rue de l'Hôpital, Rouen; <http://fromagerieolivier.free.fr>

Possibly the best cheese shop in France, with a huge choice of French and Normandy cheeses, including exquisite artisan-made Camembert.

La Route du Fromage

Livarot; www.paysdelivarot.fr

A selection of farms in the picturesque Pays d'Auge region – which includes big-cheese villages such as Livarot, Pont l'Évêque, and Camembert – offer tastings as well as cheese for sale. Pick up a map of the touring route at a local tourist office.

FRANCHE-COMTE, FRANCE

This unspoiled region on the eastern edge of France produces tangy, traditionally made Comté, the country's biggest-selling hard cheese. Other popular local picks for the cheese board include Mont d'Or and Morbier.

Fromagerie Marcel Petite

22 rue Bernard Palissy, Granges Narboz; www.comte-petite.com

Here you can see how impressive 65,000 wheels of Comté look stored in a converted fort, and follow up the adventure with a tasting in these atmospheric surroundings.

La Fromagerie du Mont d'Or

2 rue du Moulin, Métabief; +33 3 81 490 236

A cheese shop specializing in the rich, runny Mont d'Or cheese, a French Christmas favorite that is only available from September to March. Morbier cheese is also offered. The fromagerie uses the milk from 13 regional producers.

